

CHAPTER 6

Democracy

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡
answers are samples: write your own.
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The Big Questions

1 **How has the idea of democracy evolved over time and shaped our understanding of it today?**

✔ ANSWER

- Democratic ideas have been part of India since early times: Vedic assemblies like Sabha, Samiti and Vidhata, and early republics (gaṇas or saṁghas) made decisions together.
- The Bauddha Saṁghas chose leaders and decided by voting.
- Foreign rule limited people's participation, but the freedom struggle revived democratic ideas.
- The Constituent Assembly (1946) drew on Indian traditions and global democratic values to make a flexible Constitution.
- So today we see democracy as a continuous process, not only elections.

2 **What are the different forms of democracy, and how are they practised in India and other parts of the world?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Direct democracy:** citizens directly take most decisions, e.g. Switzerland.

- **Representative (indirect) democracy:** people elect representatives, e.g. India.
- Representative democracy can be **parliamentary** (executive is part of and accountable to the legislature, e.g. India, Canada, UK) or **presidential** (President elected by people, independent of the legislature, e.g. USA).
- The UK is a parliamentary democracy with a constitutional monarchy and an unwritten constitution.

3 **What are the essential features of a democracy and how do they extend beyond government institutions?**

✔ ANSWER

- Features: popular sovereignty, rule of law, Fundamental Rights, separation of powers, accountability and transparency, multi-party system, protecting vulnerable groups.
- Beyond government: civil society groups, cooperatives, trade unions and community institutions also decide democratically.
- Media (the 'fourth pillar'), Gram Sabhas and active citizens keep democracy alive in everyday life.

4 **What are the challenges faced by Indian democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

- Illiteracy, poverty, inequality, regionalism, gender inequality and social discrimination.
- Misinformation and fake news, especially on social media.
- Gaps in implementing laws and policies, which reduce public trust.
- Careless citizen behaviour (damaging public property, breaking rules, indifference).
- History shows a major challenge: the Emergency of 1975–77.

🤔 Think About It · Popular Sovereignty

• **Why is it important that the ultimate source of power rests with the people in a democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

- The government gets its authority from the people, so it must work for them.
- People can change a government that does not serve them well.
- It prevents any one person or group from ruling by force and protects people's rights.

How does people's participation through voting strengthen popular sovereignty?

✔ ANSWER

- Through voting (Universal Adult Franchise, 18+, secret ballot) citizens choose their representatives and government.
- Regular voting keeps the government answerable to the people.
- The more people vote, the more the government truly reflects the will of the people.

⭐ Let's Explore · Fundamental Rights

The Constitution guarantees Fundamental Rights and also outlines Fundamental Duties and the Directive Principles of State Policy. Discuss their significance and identify the differences among them.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Fundamental Rights	Fundamental Duties	Directive Principles
Freedoms and protections for citizens	Responsibilities of citizens towards the nation	Guidelines for the government to make policies
Enforceable in courts	Not enforceable in courts	Not enforceable in courts

Protect dignity and freedom of the individual	Build good citizenship and unity	Aim at social and economic welfare

Significance: Rights protect citizens, duties remind them of their role, and Directive Principles guide the State to build a just, welfare society. Together they balance rights and responsibilities.

The Right to Education (Article 21A) was added in 2009, ensuring free and compulsory education for children aged 6 to 14. Discuss its significance.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Every child aged 6–14 gets free and compulsory education, whatever their family's income.
- Education helps people know their rights and duties and take part in democracy.
- It reduces inequality and child labour and gives poor and vulnerable children equal opportunity.

🤔 Think About It · Separation of Powers

What do you think would happen if the same organ of the government made laws, implemented them, and enforced them? Share your thoughts.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- All power would be concentrated in one organ, and there would be no checks and balances.
- It could misuse power, make unfair laws and act arbitrarily.
- Citizens' rights would not be safe, as no independent body could review its actions. This could lead to dictatorship.

⭐ Let's Explore · Features of Democracy in Your Area

Fill in the second column with suitable examples from your state, town, or village. (One row is done: Accountability and Transparency – Question Hour, auditing of government accounts, Right to Information.)

Features of Democracy	Examples
Popular Sovereignty	
Rule of Law	
Separation of Powers	
Fundamental Rights	

Accountability and Transparency	**Question Hour, audit of accounts, RTI (given)**
Multi-Party System	

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Features of Democracy	Examples
Popular Sovereignty	People vote to elect their MLA, MP and Gram Panchayat/ward members
Rule of Law	A local official who takes a bribe is tried in court like anyone else
Separation of Powers	State Assembly makes laws, state government implements them, High Court can strike down unconstitutional laws
Fundamental Rights	Children in the village attend free government school (Right to Education); everyone can enter public places
Accountability and Transparency	Question Hour, audit of government accounts, RTI applications
Multi-Party System	Many parties contest the state assembly and local body elections

⭐ Let's Explore · Types of Democracy

Select your ideal team from Fig. 6.5 (Teams A–D) and give reasons for your selection.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Team B (sample choice).

- Every class elects a representative, so all students are represented, like India's representative democracy.
- Elections are held every year, so representatives stay accountable.
- The President and representatives decide together, so power is shared.

(Team D is least democratic: only selected candidates can contest, power is concentrated and opposition is discouraged.)

⭐ Let's Explore · Democracy in India's Neighbourhood

Choose any two of India's neighbouring countries and find out:

- **Does the country hold regular elections?**
- **Who chooses the Head of the Government?**
- **Is there more than one political party?**
- **How much freedom do citizens have to express opinions and criticise the government?**

How would you describe this system: Democratic, Partially democratic or Non-democratic? Give reasons.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample (check current facts in news sources):

Question	Nepal	China
Regular elections?	Yes, parliamentary elections	No free multi-party national elections
Who chooses Head of Government?	Elected Parliament (Prime Minister)	Communist Party leadership
More than one party?	Yes, many parties	Only one ruling party holds power
Freedom to criticise?	Fairly free	Very limited
System	Democratic	Non-democratic

Reason: a democracy needs free, regular elections, many parties and freedom of expression.

Democracy in Practice: India's Living Democracy

? **Based on the given facts and figures (over 96.8 crore voters, 22 scheduled languages, over one million polling stations, over 2,800 parties), imagine the strength of Indian democracy.**

✔ ANSWER

- Over 96.8 crore voters (2024) – more than the population of many countries.
- More than one million polling stations, even in mountains, forests, deserts, islands, and sometimes for a single voter: no citizen is left out.
- Elections in 22 scheduled languages, with symbols so that people who cannot read can vote.
- Over 2,800 parties let many viewpoints compete peacefully.

So Indian democracy is huge, inclusive and well-organised – the world's largest democracy.

Let's Explore · Democracy at the Grassroots

• **A democratic system seeks to promote participation, ensure fairness, limit the concentration of power, and resolve disagreements peacefully. Identify examples**

from the case study that reflect these features.

✔ ANSWER

- **Participation:** Jethipura held regular and Special Gram Sabhas and Mahila Sabhas with adequate quorum; South Manubankul promotes women's role in decisions.
- **Fairness:** active participation of SCs, STs and women; focus on welfare of women and children; self-help groups.
- **Limiting concentration of power:** decisions taken in the Gram Sabha by the people, not by one leader; proper records kept.
- **Resolving disagreements peacefully:** issues of education, sanitation and welfare discussed and settled in Gram Sabha meetings.

⭐ Let's Explore · Women and the Right to Vote

Discuss in class the advantages of increased representation of women in the legislature.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Women make up about half the population, so more women make the legislature truly representative.
- Issues like health, safety, education and welfare of women and children get more attention.

- It breaks social prejudices and inspires more women and girls to lead.
- It makes democracy more inclusive and decisions more balanced.

🤔 Think About It · Grassroots Democracy

Explore and discuss the contributions of eminent Indian leaders who worked towards strengthening grassroots democracy.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Chaudhary Charan Singh** and **Babu Jagjivan Ram** came from rural backgrounds and spoke for the rights of the rural poor and other marginalised sections (from the chapter).
- **Mahatma Gandhi** dreamt of self-reliant villages run by Gram Panchayats (Gram Swaraj).
- **Jayaprakash Narayan** mobilised students and citizens to defend democracy.

Such leaders helped make the village a strong unit of democracy.

⭐ Let's Explore · Challenges to Democratic Practices

In small groups, identify two or three examples of information on social media that may be misleading or false. Discuss what

made you question them, how they influence opinions, and why accurate information matters in a democracy.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Examples: a forwarded message claiming the government will give free money to everyone who shares it; an edited photo shown as a recent riot; a fake 'cure' for a disease.

- Doubts: no official source, emotional or urgent language, spelling mistakes, very old or edited images.
- Influence: they create confusion and fear, mislead voters and can even lead to conflict.
- Accurate information lets citizens form informed opinions and make right choices while voting.

⭐ Let's Explore · Democracy and You

Observe Fig. 6.9 and explore the various other digital and non-digital ways through which you can participate in a democracy.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Fig. 6.9 shows: understand the Constitution, follow fundamental duties, be media literate, take leadership in school and community, join NCC, NSS, Bharat Scouts & Guides.

Other ways:

- Digital: give feedback on government portals, file an RTI, check facts before sharing, join online public consultations.
- Non-digital: vote in school elections, attend Gram Sabha/ward meetings with elders, join cleanliness drives, help people register as voters when they turn 18.

🤔 Think, Discuss, Act

Think **How do your actions as a student contribute to your school community and to democracy in a larger context?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Following rules, respecting others' views, voting in school elections, caring for school property and helping classmates build habits of fairness and responsibility that democracy needs.

Discuss **Talk about a social or community issue that you care about. How can you, as a student, make a difference?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Issue: garbage in the locality. I can spread awareness, start a cleanliness drive with friends, separate waste at home and write to the ward member or panchayat.

Act **Choose one activity to fulfil your civic responsibility this month and reflect on it.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Activity: a weekly cleanliness drive near school. It builds teamwork and shows that citizens, not just the government, keep the community healthy – this strengthens democracy and community spirit.

? Questions and activities

1 (a) **A school cabinet planning a Republic Day celebration had different opinions on activities. After discussion, they voted and chose the activities supported by the majority.**

Which democratic values are reflected in this situation?

✔ **ANSWER**

Discussion and debate, participation, equality (each member's vote counts equally), respect for different opinions and majority decision-making.

1 (b) **How does voting help resolve differences of opinion?**

✔ **ANSWER**

Voting lets everyone express their choice fairly and peacefully. The option with the most support is chosen, so the disagreement ends without force.

1 (c) **Why is the majority decision important in a democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

It shows what most people want, gives the decision legitimacy and lets the group move forward. Minority views should still be respected.

1 (d) **Mention responsibilities of elected representatives after a decision is made.**

✔ ANSWER

- Carry out the decision honestly and on time.
- Work for everyone, including those who disagreed.
- Stay accountable: explain their actions and use resources properly.

2 **How would democracy be affected if citizens stopped following laws and civic responsibilities? Explain with an example.**

✔ ANSWER

- The rule of law would weaken, there would be disorder, and people's rights would not be safe.
- Public trust in institutions would fall.

Example: if people damage public property or spread misinformation, public services suffer and confusion or conflict can arise. The chapter says such actions weaken democratic values.

3 **Which situation best reflects the idea of popular sovereignty and why?**

a. A law is passed without public discussion

b. Citizens vote to choose their representatives

c. A court gives a final judgment

d. A minister takes an independent decision

✔ ANSWER

(b) Citizens vote to choose their representatives – power comes from the people, who give authority to the government through voting.

4 **The Rule of Law is violated when:**

a. Laws are applied equally to all

b. Courts review government actions

c. Powerful individuals are treated above the law

d. Citizens challenge laws through legal means

✔ ANSWER

(c) Powerful individuals are treated above the law – the Rule of Law means no one is above the law.

5 **Why is the Rule of Law essential for protecting democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

- It ensures equality before the law and equal protection of the law; no one is above the law.
- Disputes are settled in courts by procedure established by law, not by force or influence.
- It prevents misuse of power, protects rights, and promotes justice, accountability and trust.

6 **Is voting alone enough to make a country democratic? Support your answer with examples from the chapter.**

✔ ANSWER

No. Voting is important, but democracy also needs:

- Rule of law, Fundamental Rights and separation of powers.

- Accountability and transparency (RTI Act 2005, Question Hour).
- Participation beyond elections, e.g. Gram Sabhas in Jethipura and South Manubankul.
- Example: in Team D (Fig. 6.5) elections are held, but only selected candidates contest and opposition is weak, so it is not truly democratic. During the Emergency (1975–77) rights were suspended and the press censored.

7 (a) **Social media allows people to express opinions freely. How can this strengthen democracy?**

✔ ANSWER

It raises public issues, spreads information quickly, lets citizens share views and question the government, and increases participation – it acts as a voice of the masses.

7 (b) **How can it weaken democracy if used irresponsibly?**

✔ ANSWER

Fake news and misinformation can mislead public opinion, create confusion and even lead to conflict. It can also spread hatred between communities.

8 **Write a paragraph on what democracy means to you as a young citizen.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

To me, democracy means that every person's voice matters. It gives me the freedom to speak, learn and grow, and equal rights whatever my caste, religion or gender. It also means duties: I must follow laws, respect others, check facts before sharing, and take part in my school and community. When I turn 18, I will vote wisely. Democracy is not only the government's work; it is strong when citizens like me are informed and responsible.

9 **Conduct a model parliament session or Gram Sabha in class on local issues—cleanliness, responsibilities towards public property, or school safety.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample plan (Gram Sabha on cleanliness):

- Choose a Sarpanch, a secretary to keep records, and members; check the quorum.
- Members raise problems (garbage near the gate, dirty toilets).
- Discuss solutions; every member gets a chance to speak.
- Vote on proposals (dustbins in each corridor, weekly cleaning duty).

- Record the decisions and review progress after a month.

10 **Choose any one democratic institution in India (Parliament, Election Commission, Judiciary, or Panchayat). Prepare a short note on (a) its role in democracy and (b) how it ensures accountability and participation.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Gram Panchayat (sample)

(a) Role: the local self-government of a village; plans and runs work on education, sanitation, health, and welfare of women and children, and implements government schemes.

(b) Accountability and participation: it holds Gram Sabhas where villagers question its work and decide together; records are kept; at least one-third seats (50% in many states) are reserved for women; SCs, STs and women take part (e.g. Jethipura, South Manubankul).

11 **What role does the Constitution play in strengthening democracy in India?**

✔ ANSWER

- It provides popular sovereignty and Universal Adult Franchise.
- It guarantees Fundamental Rights and lists Fundamental Duties.

- It sets up the rule of law and separation of powers among legislature, executive and judiciary.
- It protects vulnerable groups (e.g. Article 46) and reserves seats for women in local bodies.
- It can be amended (Article 368), so it stays flexible to changing needs.

12 **What challenges do you think democracy in India faces today?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- Fake news and misinformation on social media.
- Illiteracy, poverty and inequality.
- Regionalism, gender inequality and social discrimination.
- Gaps in implementing laws and policies, reducing trust.
- Citizens' indifference and irresponsible behaviour like damaging public property.

🎉 **Chapter 6 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**